

Rendering Techniques

The major approaches to applying tone

Rendering is the process of applying tone — value, texture, and surface quality — to a drawing. There are many techniques, each with its strengths. Mastering even two or three gives you enormous expressive range.

KEY CONCEPTS

Blending

Using a blending stump, finger, or soft brush to smooth and merge pencil marks into seamless gradients. Excellent for smooth surfaces, skin, glass. Risk: over-blending loses texture and mark quality. Use sparingly.

Hatching & Cross-Hatching

Building tone with parallel or crossed lines. More expressive than blending — the individual marks are visible. Great for pen/ink and when you want mark-making to be part of the aesthetic.

Scumbling

Loose, circular or random overlapping marks that build up irregular textures. Good for rough surfaces, foliage, grass, fur. Feels more painterly than hatching. Works well with charcoal and soft pencils.

Stippling

Building tone entirely with dots. The closer the dots, the darker the tone. Extremely time-consuming but produces beautiful, unique results. Associated with pen and ink, etching, and medical illustration.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Do a 3-value sphere using ONLY blending. Then redo it with ONLY hatching. Compare.
2. Do a full-page texture sampler: 6 different techniques, each filling a box.
3. Draw a portrait using only stippling. Focus on patience and dot density.

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Rendering Techniques

<https://youtu.be/OcJPNMFFKHs>

■ New Masters – Mark Making

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b_w_hdwaIV8